





Ottoman campaigns
The Siege of Belgrade in 1456 led by Sultan Mehmet II "The Conqueror" *(right)* and the typical arms and armour of an Ottoman soldier *(far right)*. The siege eventually escalated into a major battle, during which John Hunyadi led a sudden counterattack that overran the Turkish camp, ultimately compelling the wounded Sultan to retreat.

> "...THEN EACH [WARRIOR] WAS ORDERED TO KILL HIS OWN PRISONERS, AND FOR THOSE WHO DID NOT WISH TO DO SO THE KING [BAYEZID] APPOINTED OTHERS IN THEIR PLACE."
>
> **JOHANN SCHILTBERGER** DESCRIBING THE CRUSADE OF NICOPOLIS, 1396

Other cavalry were recruited as *akinji*. They were ambitious young warriors with a horse and a taste for adventure who viewed warfare as a chance to make their way in the world. The *akinji* served as light cavalry – scouting and raiding ahead of the main army. They profited from plunder and might hope, if their valour attracted official attention, to one day be granted a *timar*. At the bottom of the army hierarchy were the *azabs*. They served as manual labourers and as foot soldiers, and were regarded as dispensable cannon fodder. Finally, an important contribution to Ottoman forces was made by countries owing allegiance to the sultan that provided national contingents under their own commanders – for example, the Serbs from the late 14th century.

SLAVE-SOLDIERS

Like most Muslim states, the Ottomans employed slaves both in high administration and to form elite troops in the armed forces – the Mamluks in Egypt were a prime example. The janissary corps was raised through the *devshirme*, a selective conscription of boys from the Christian communities of the Balkans that came under Ottoman rule in the 14th century. Ottoman press gangs toured the Balkans every year, taking the children that looked the most promising military material. Removed from their Christian families, the boys were taken back to Constantinople and raised as Muslims. When they came of age they entered the sultan's service, either as janissaries or as civilian administrators. Forbidden to marry or own property and definitively separated from their families, the slave-soldiers were regarded as the ideal faithful servants of the sultan because they had no other attachments or personal ambitions. What the system failed to allow for was the inevitable development over time of the janissaries' loyalty to their own corps, which in the end would make them devoted less to the sultan than to their own interests as a military elite. However, in their golden age before self-interest took hold, they were fine infantrymen, disciplined, ascetic, fearless, and skilled in the use of firearms. They were the troops expected to storm the walls of a besieged fortress or hold the line on the battlefield in the face of charging enemy cavalry.



Warrior's cuirass
This example of Ottoman body armour would have provided superb protection, featuring several large plates and shoulder guards.

EFFECTIVE FIGHTERS

Although large and variegated, the Ottoman army was noted for the good order of its military operations, with camps clean and well organized and the off-duty behaviour of soldiers less

Ottoman weapons
A miquelet rifle and a *gurz* (mace) – both 18th century. Although Ottoman forces readily deployed firearms in battle, they rejected the use of the bayonet, seeing it as an "infidel weapon".



MIQUELET RIFLE

OTTOMAN GURZ